Lizka Vaintrob
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What it's like to be an AI safety grantmaker (and why we need more of them) [1]

AI safety · Career choice · Existential risk · Grants · Building the field of AI safety · 9 more

This is a linkpost for https://open.substack.com/pub/lizkavintrob/p/what-its-like-to-be-an-ai-safety-grantmaker

TL;DR

Here are the key points I want you to take away from this post:

1. There are maybe 30 to 40 people in the world doing AI safety grantmaking, collectively directing hundreds of millions of dollars a year. Soon, there will be (\$1B being divvied up per year, and potentially multiple billions.
2. The AI safety grantmaking space is very small, and has a strong lack of counterfactually-sensitive/high-expectation-and-variance people.
3. The AI safety grantmaking ecosystem is becoming a rarity of informed projects. Most grantmakers are generalists who don't have specific bottlenecks in mind, and many non-funding programs provide strategic advice to grantees, write memos that help applicants understand what's wanted, or even run a semi-in-house fellowship.
4. The AI safety grantmaking ecosystem is currently leaving good grant opportunities on the table. Some of the reasons for this are:
   - Many grantmakers would also advise more capable founders that they are not willing to refer/pass them over people who can find and vet opportunities themselves.
   - The ecosystem thinks that we should not necessarily be encouraging founders. Direct work is great, and the entire ecosystem is taken out/vetted in many ways. But my view is that grantmaking is understated relative to what non-public-facing content AI safety people need to consider, like research or policy.
   - Grantmakers are generally overworked, and don't have the capacity to give as much support to as many projects as they'd like. It's also hard to coordinate well, and to keep up with everything that's happening in the space. Both of these are bottlenecks.
   - Grantmakers are generally not well-calibrated, and don't have enough feedback loops. I'll discuss these in the appendix.

Intro

A few months ago, I wrapped up my two-and-a-half year stint as a grantmaster on the AI [2] grantmaker and policy team at Coefficient Giving (or Coefficient Giving for short [3]). I'm joining Anthropic's Frontier Red Team to do something entirely different.

CG was my first, real job. I have no idea how AI safety job ads are functioning good school. The CS degree I'm halfway through? Probably not necessary. Specific AI safety knowledge? Definitely helpful, but I'm not sure it's a dealbreaker. Of course I'd have been a stronger candidate if I had an extensive/full-time AIS subscription I decided grantmaking was the most impactful job I could pursue.

Nope. I took this job for basic reasons:

- I wanted an AI safety job, and this was the only one available to me at the moment.
- CG cites (often! Open Philanthropy!) back a bunch of cool people working there, such as Ajeya Cotra and Luke Muehlhauser. Working with cool people is good* (and I'm a reasonable heuristic, I guess?).
- I was curious about the grantmaking role, and I needed to play one well to find out for myself.

Fortunately, I ended up spectacularly overshooting the grantmaking by a very high leverage role. I'm not sure I'll be able to find another job that's as interesting, impactful, and fun. But I'm glad I took the shot, and that grantmaking is being professionalized in a career opportunity for high-context, AI safety people.

I'll also try to address some common misconceptions about things like the marginal value of more/less talent, how CG selects/assesses downsides of the role, and outline a basic call to action.

What do grantmakers do?

Grantmaking mostly involves three key activities: (1) evaluating inbound grant applications, (2) sourcing and investigating potential grants ("proactive" or "active grantmaking"), and (3) a guilt trip of non-grantmaking activities.

I'll describe each of these below to more detail, but the basic idea is that grantmakers are on the lookout or figuring out or either the AI safety ecosystem needs and then taking advantage of the biggest flaws available to them to make it happen. [4]

Passive grantmaking

This is the most straightforward one: when they think about what grantmakers do.

Grantmakers have a pool of money to distribute, and conduct an investigation, and if you think it's worth funding, we make a recommendation that some project or your organization can get funded.

A common misconception about passive grantmaking is that it basically just involves being swamp of spam emails. That's false: you have a lot of human or at least plausible-to-an-informed-grant-bot-something-went-from. You can grab the applicant feedback on your own, and you can't just ignore the good ones. Also, the best applicants are often nonhuman and active donors and people to choose the great portal, really, the second half of the grant conducted on hiring certain references, suggest they look for their own individual and/or push them to the more active methods.

Active grantmaking

There's a second "half" of grantmaking called active grantmaking.

Instead of waiting for exciting projects to land on your desk, you go out and actually make things happen. For instance, you could write up a project proposal in an organization focused on a sub-problem you think is important and pitch a number of potential founders to start it. You could also design and advertise a new funding program from scratch (e.g., an RFP or something like CG's CB3T program), and/or push on existing projects to meet some milestones.

Active grantmaking requires you to develop models of how a situation. You have to draw memos on questions like:

- What are the most important threat models to focus on?
- What are the bottlenecks in the AI safety ecosystem?
  - CG policy development?
  - Information security field-building?
  - Technical AI governance research?
  - ITs, policy?
  - Strategic communications?
  - Talent pipelines?
- What are the most promising bets/gaps actually look like right now? Who is working on them?
- Which organizations and people are doing the best work? What's currently bottlenecking them?
- What's the biggest gap in the ecosystem that nobody's filling?

You develop these views through a mix of reading papers, memos, blogs, Slack messages, talking to a lot of people (researchers, founders, policy experts, other grantmakers), and occasionally just sitting with a hard question for a while.

This said, even at an organization that's been grantmaking for a decade, there are a lot of questions that haven't been thought about much. Often, you're the first person in the area. Even just a week or so of dedicated investigating can save a few bad bets on the team's radar but never properly investigated can surface genuinely exciting opportunities. Every organization has blindspots, and sometimes the thing a new grantmaker can do is simply the first person to take a serious look at something that seems worth grantmaking.

Non-grantmaking activities

A surprising amount of the job doesn't involve making grants directly. As a grantmaker, you can easily spend a decent chunk of your time on high-value things like:

- Providing strategic advice to grantees — helping them think through organizational strategy, prioritization, etc.
- Helping grantees problem-solve: make intros or your leadership/thinks about certain challenges they're facing, suggest ideas for how to overcome them.
- Writing external memos that shape how the broader ecosystem thinks about various strategy questions.
- Hiring, training, and managing other grantmakers.
- Making introductions between people who might work together or important projects/grantmakers are often good at being the connector-knee in the ecosystem.
- Providing feedback and referrals to grantees that are looking for help. This is: Connecting grantees to try to optimally advise the conversation on a particular topic (e.g. "What are the up-to-date views on AI control?").
  - Building relationships with other funders.
- Talking to other grantmakers (both internally and externally) about what you're both working on, so you can advise each other when making relevant grant decisions.

Throughout my time at CG, I'd guess I spent a third of my time on non-grantmaking activities. [5]

Why I think grantmaking is understatedly impactful

Grantmaking has a strong track record

During my time at CG, I saw first-hand how a number of small, speculative grants made years ago helped create organizations that are now leaders in the AI safety ecosystem.

Alexander Berger (CG's CEO) recently shared an example of this:

> "Many of the grantees that have gone on to do among our most important and impactful (AIS) work stuff starting that way at all. For instance, in mid-2017, @OpenAI grant to projects that would eventually become AI Alignment & Frontier Red Team, Safety Fundamentals, and Scalable Alignment teams. And in 2018, we made a grant to support Ought's early work, which has since become a leading AI safety nonprofit. Or a philanthropic grant to support Redwood Research's early work, which is becoming a prominent lab pursuing AI alignment research. And in 2019, we made a grant to support Anthropic's early work, which is now one of the leading labs developing frontier models and doing AI safety research. And I could go on and on, but I'll stop there."

There are more examples in this piece that CG published back in October 2023. I also like this anecdote about how Jaan Tallinn described the strike at Thinkwise as his own contribution with that piece, and this piece from Ajeya Cotra about CG's impact on building effective.

Unfortunately, many of the most impressive wins I'm familiar with are fairly sensitive, so it'll kinda just have to unusually/largely-present as a couple of fairly well-known examples (like the ones above). But I'm confident that grantmaking can be extremely impactful. If you are the one, my advice would be to ask for more evidence directly from grantmakers you speak with. Maybe they'll share a few less obvious examples they can share.

The ratio of AI safety philanthropic capital to grantmakers is kinda wild

There's something that I think people really don't appreciate: there are maybe 30-40 people in the world directing hundreds of millions of dollars a year in AI safety grants. [6]

These people collectively directed hundreds of millions of dollars a year in 2025. In 2026, I expect this number to be greater than a billion, with potentially enormous opportunities to move this even a lot higher. And these numbers don't even capture the full scale of the work: you're looking at rock-groundwork being accomplished by people who have millions of dollars per year. And extraordinary amount of leverage.

Of course, basically the entire AI safety ecosystem is talent-starved, so these executives can't fully scale the opportunities they're sitting on. But the overall picture is that grantmaking is underinvested-relative to other people-centric ecosystems. Many of the most successful founders I've met have received multiple grants totaling over a million dollars, often before they've even written a software staff engineering research work. And I know many people get a few years of runway. This seems especially true if you're someone with technical skills or degrees that is currently considering technical research roles.

This could get more weird if philanthropic capital grows but grantmaker hiring remains slow. I'm seriously worried that we're not on track to deploy all of the philanthropic capital that could be leveraged and AI safety opportunities over the next few years.

Some grantmakers would actively want more capital. More grantmakers doesn't just divide the existing pie into smaller slices. It makes the pie bigger, because funders will actually be able to be cheaper if there are more skilled grantmakers who can identify and pursue more opportunities.

Grantmakers do a lot more than through marginal proposals. As I touched on above, there's common misconception that the job is just reviewing applications. But the application and deciding which ones to say yes to. That's not true. You can go out and solve the opportunities you want to see in the world, rather than wait for them to arrive. we are not yet seeing strong diminishing returns. This can be an even bigger deal if you're someone with technical skills or degrees that is currently considering technical research roles.

Jake Mendel on CG's technical AI safety team recently wrote about this:

> "Some people think that doing a grantmaker at CapTech means sorting through a big pile of great proposals and deciding which to say yes and no to. It is true that they think the only impact of such a job (and an decision) are about whether to say yes or no to a proposal.
>
> But grantmakers don't sit around passively waiting for great proposals to come in. Instead, they spend a lot of their time trying to find great prospective new ideas and people, and thinking about how to get them off the ground. Grantmakers often have unusually broad purview on the AI safety landscape, and unusually good models of what kinds of projects and people are needed. Many grantmakers spend a lot of their time talking to researchers, founders, and other people working on AI safety, and trying to develop models of the AI safety ecosystem as a whole. Grantmakers often have to write memos about what they think AI safety needs, and they have to make judgements about how many AI safety projects there should be in various areas."

I'm also pretty sure that grantmaking can be extremely impactful for the grantmaker themselves. I'm not sure how to quantify this, but I'm confident that grantmaking can be a very high-leverage role.

Call to action

Start by thinking about whether you'd be a fit for a grantmaking role.

You might be a good fit for a grantmaker role if:

- You're good at sourcing/vetting. You are able to notice something important that nobody's working on, and/or you are able to think of creative solutions for filling those gaps.
- You like breadth over depth. This can look like forming a fool's eye view of what matters in AI safety, and/or being excited to learn a lot about a lot. You're also comfortable with being somewhat/highly skeptical about many sub-areas rather than building world-class expertise in one.
- You have strong people judgement skills. You go beyond evaluating whether a theory of change is sound on paper to evaluating whether the particular people involved can actually execute.
- You're action-oriented. You prefer experimenting to perspective, you can prioritize between different problems, design interventions to solve them, persuade others to work on them, and deploy capital to fulfill your own strategic vision. You can get a lot of leverage if you're good at these things.
- You're a clear communicator. Much of grantmaking is communications-heavy work. You're writing memos, giving advice, and persuading people to do things, and clearly explaining why you're excited about some opportunity is worker decisionmakers.

That said, I want to be clear that grantmakers come from all kinds of backgrounds. I don't personally fit all of the above points very well. I'm not a "hard" STEM person, I'm not very research-interesting, still, a new generalists and I wouldn't be a natural fit for the role applying. You'll learn a lot about the role from the process (until even if it doesn't result, see I did a lot of hiring at CG), and while there wasn't one very experienced, I would've loved to see more work-history AI safety people apply.

If you want to pursue this, see the above and external organizations that are worth keeping an eye on:

- Coefficient Giving: the largest AI safety funder by a wide margin, with teams working on technical AI safety, AI governance and policy, biosecurity, global catastrophic risks, and capacity-building.
  - Despite my recent departure, I'm still very bullish on CG!
- Longview Philanthropy: they have their own AI program and do major donors on AI safety giving.
- Macroscopic Ventures: they make grants and investments in AI safety and related areas.
- Astralis Foundation: where I'm heading now. We're a newer and smaller funder, but we're growing.
- The Long-Term Future Fund: fund managers evaluate applications on a rolling basis and make grants to individuals and organizations working on AI safety.
- Future of Life Foundation: FLF does grantmaking and runs a number of AI safety initiatives.

There are also opportunities at the grant-making government agencies like the Survival and Flourishing Fund. You could also do independent grantmaking or set up your own new thing, which can have a great system if you're particularly entrepreneurial and if you can access funding. [7]

Acknowledgements: Thank you to Catherine Brewer, Michael Townsend and Trevor Levin for their helpful comments. All views expressed here are my own and do not necessarily reflect my own employers or individuals I've worked with.

Appendix - Things that aren't great about grantmaking

In the interest of not writing a pro-role pitch here, here are some things I think are genuine downsides of being a grantmaker.

You might not go as deep on the object-level as you might want to. It goes more than a fairly strong correlation between people who are hungry into AI safety and people who intrinsically love thinking about the models where more on specific questions. Grantmaking isn't really set up for that. As I described above, you'll spend some of your time developing models of the space, but you're not going to be doing research or writing papers with that. But generally speaking your members will be pretty broad and you'll have to keep a decent amount. If what you really want is to spend six months going deep on a single research question, grantmaking is probably not the right fit for you.

The work is somewhat terrible. If you make a great grant, your broader network of people will probably hear about it. But you're not going to get much credit for it. This is, for instance, true in both science and academia — I can produce something that helps people can evaluate and credit you for. Grantmaking doesn't really have that. Of course, you do get some praise from people who appreciate that grantmaking can be an important contribution to the ecosystem, but the actual work is largely behind the scenes.

People will sometimes be mad at you. Grantmakers can piss people off by saying no. It can be somewhat rare of people trying to bamboozle you in the process, this was fun for all we have been surprised pretty low on the number of people I interacted with were relatively honest and well-intentioned. But there are glitches out there, and developing a knack for this is part of the job.

Active grantmaking can be really tricky. The most entrepreneurial parts of grantmaking can require you to develop models of the space that are unusual for you to take very early on (more detail on this soon). This can be some of the most exciting work that a grantmaker does, but also some of the hardest.

You sometimes can't fund things you think are good. Depending on where you work, there may be constraints on what you can fund, for one reason or another. Maybe it's a conflict of interest, maybe it's a specific cause area that your organization doesn't want to fund. And sometimes they'll have less preferences about funding things you're cool-adverse areas or supports, or there might be other organizational constraints that get in your way. That's just the way it is. [8]

Saying no is hard. It tends to be easy to be overconfident in why it really pessimism about them (also, that's part of the job). This is especially true when there's some pressure saying no is because of bandwidth constraints rather than their proposal being below the bar.

Communicating can be quite effortful. You have to be pretty careful about how you communicate publicly and privately, and there's a lot of potential for people to get worried/misunderstood. A poorly-worded email from a grantmaker can carry more weight than you intend.

If, as many folk imagine, the biggest form-ecosystem is when philanthropically capital. But interesting to use for your network or your particular object-level knowledge.

Of course, other grantmakers might have vastly different experiences with this.

I'm drawing heavily on CG examples here because that's what I know best, not because CG is the only funder with roles like these. My sense is that other grantmakers might have similar routes to sell.

This was just a 30 minute two-candidates-minimum I put together as of March 2026. If you expand the criteria to include program leadership, advisory roles, and people in grantmaking-adjacent positions, you get to maybe 70-ish.

Even then, I think people overestimate how obvious these are!

The example of something that I think is probably more well-figured-out grantmaking is founding and scaling highly ambitious organizations. But even that's not quite right: I think that there are many ambitious organizations that could be founded, and I think that there's still room for a very-top-of-the-grantmaking-funnel AI safety person-level, it might be kind of a dive-off.

This depends on factors such as what organizations you work at, what period you focus on, and your level of seniority.

In practice, I didn't feel like this was a huge issue for me during my role (CG I know others who have much tougher issues with this enough, or YSMV).

Mentioned in
- The Anthropic IPO Is Coming. We Aren't Ready for It.
- Open Questions in AI Safety: What We Know and What We Don't
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Sarah Shoemaker 2mo · 1 · ▲ 7 ▼ 0 · 🔗

Thanks, I am very excited about the kinds/volumes of co-funding there to look for grantmakers! It seems like there are always many bright young people who want to work for EA charities — what's your current sense of the bottlenecks to finding more great grantmakers?

> **AdamGleave** 2mo · 1 · ▲ 4 ▼ 0 · 🔗
>
> I'd add to this:
>
> - Grantmakers are generally overworked and don't have much time for reflection. It's always easy to have that much harder-to-justify-but-clearly-important tasks that there are no deadlines for, and so they get neglected.
> - Relatively related, for various of such experienced AI safety focused people who are otherwise skilled, is lack of entrepreneurship. Not just strategists, and tech teams are much more of a bottleneck than I'd have expected. Many of the most successful grantees I've seen are entrepreneurial founders who identified a gap and founded a new org to launch at target area.
>   - Corollary here: despite some pros who have experimented on key team issues by trying new things, I think there's still too much of a culture of "do what you're told".
> - Grantmaking means giving someone decent amounts of influence over how to spend money, and you get recommended pretty cautious about entrusting that authority.
>   - Corollary: grantmakers are often reluctant to fund people who they think are smart and capable but who don't quite command some form of open reputation.
>   - Corollary: grantmakers are often reluctant to fund people who they think are capable but who don't have a clear enough plan for how they're going to spend the money. They would like to offer more "coaching" than they have time for.
> - CG has admirably good strength at make mistakes around being too slowly in the past (and, to a lesser extent, still today). Grantmakers are often reluctant to fund people who they think the ecosystem is too much, but CG is much a large portion of the total deployment of capital, so there is the ability to encourage CG more.

Sarah Hastings-Woodhouse 2mo · 1 · ▲ 4 ▼ 0 · 🔗

I'm a huge believer in setting person-specific bottlenecks, say, working as a researcher at Anthropic, and I'm very glad that you're doing this. That said, I'm somewhat surprised by the emphasis on grantmaking as the solution to the problem of talent-constrained AI safety. I'd have guessed, especially now if you're someone with technical skills or degrees that is currently considering technical research roles.

Seems true to me. I'd like to see more talented grant makers out there!

Reply

Austin 6mo* 12 0 0 1

> There are maybe 30 to 60 people in the world doing AI safety grantmaking, collectively directing hundreds of millions of dollars a year. Soon, there will be >$1B being directed per year, and potentially multiple billions.

I like this framing for the botecs it encourages!

Currently it seems like each grantmaker is (on average) responsible for ~$10m/y. One question I think about sometimes: how will # of grantmakers scale as more $ go towards AI safety funding? If funding is eg 3x'ing year-over-year, it's unclear whether we're currently training up that number of grantmakers.

Another question might be: what is a good ratio of # of grantmakers to # of direct work? I'd ballpark there to be ~1000 fulltime AIS direct workers; does a 20:1 ratio seem high, low, or just right?

I'd be curious to look at comparisons for scaled funding ecosystems for a reference class; I'm primarily thinking VCs & angels, but perhaps others eg academic funding are also appropriate.

Reply

JulianHazell 6mo 11 2 0 1

> Currently it seems like each grantmaker is (on average) responsible for ~$10m/y. One question I think about sometimes: how will # of grantmakers scale as more $ go towards AI safety funding? If funding is eg 3x'ing year-over-year, it's unclear whether we're currently training up that number of grantmakers.

My vibes-based sense is that at least currently, the amount of philanthropic capital that could go towards AI safety projects is growing quite a bit faster than the number of grantmakers. I'm pretty worried about this.

Taking a look at CG:

- Per this, the number of GCR program staff at CG only grew 2x from 2019 to 2022.
- Quickly looking at archives of the team list from EOTY 2022 and EOTY 2025, it looks like the growth rate of program staff over that period was roughly 2 to 2.5x.

> Another question might be: what is a good ratio of # of grantmakers to # of direct work? I'd ballpark there to be ~1000 fulltime AIS direct workers; does a 20:1 ratio seem high, low, or just right?

I think the ratio framing is a bit tricky and depends on a lot of other variables (for instance, how mature the field is, how many promising ideas are floating around the memesphere, how good AIs are at doing direct work, how much philanthropic capital there is, etc). The other thing is that the number of direct workers is itself downstream of grantmaker capacity.

Reply

Tony Senanayake 6mo 7 0 0

Thanks for sharing this post. I appreciated the honest behind-the-scenes look at what is involved in being a grant maker.

As someone not working in the AI safety space, I'm intrigued by your opinions as to what extent grant making within AI safety is similar to and different from grant making within other cause priority areas, for example animal advocacy and global development and health?

My sense from reading the post is that those areas may be relatively less neglected, with fewer opportunities for identifying opportunities with outsized impact returns on investment. Do you think that is a reasonable assumption to be making?

Reply

JulianHazell 6mo 6 0 0

Thanks for the comment!

> As someone not working in the AI safety space, I'm intrigued by your opinions as to what extent grant making within AI safety is similar to and different from grant making within other cause priority areas, for example animal advocacy and global development and health?

It's hard for me to say about what these differences look like outside of CG, but one thing that comes to mind is that GHW and animal welfare grantmaking is more based on quantitative modelling and BOTECs (though sometimes we use BOTECs on the GCR side of things).

> My sense from reading the post is that those areas may be relatively less neglected, with fewer opportunities for identifying opportunities with outsized impact returns on investment. Do you think that is a reasonable assumption to be making?

It depends on how you define "neglected". Like, in terms of EA focus and talent, they're probably more neglected than AI safety/catastrophic risks. In terms of total $ spent by society at large, GHW is far less neglected than AI safety, which is in turn far less neglected than FAW.

This is kind of a lame answer, but whether AI safety has more or fewer outsized ROI opportunities really depends on your worldview. IMO, both spaces have a ton of opportunity. If I woke up tomorrow and decided that AI safety was no longer important (or I didn't buy that worldview anymore), I'd be extremely excited about the vast number of opportunities to make global health and farmed animal welfare better.

Reply

Greg_Colbourn ⏸️ 6mo 2 0 1

The whole AI Safety grantmaking sector is woefully underinvesting in Pause-related initiatives. It's a tragedy that the world will probably end with so little resources going into pushing for the one solution that might actually prevent it from happening - an international ban (and taboo) on ASI.

Reply

Greg_Colbourn ⏸️ 6mo 1 0 3

But of course the reason for this is corruption of the entire mission by Anthropic shareholding. I really hope that Dustin will see the light in time and do something about it..

Reply

[anonymous] 5mo* 2 0 0

Thanks for this, I entirely agree.

I'd love to see more infrastructure put in place to resolve this problem. I'd like current funders to aim for a world where we have so many capable grantmakers that some are occasionally underused because there is not enough funding to allocate.

For instance, that might involve programs to proactively identify people with skills relevant to grantmaking, such as forecasting, headhunting, and transparent reasoning, funding them generously to participate in grantmaking fellowships, and placing them in grantmaking organizations when there is a strong fit.

Reply

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